

See also: The Sherman Antitrust Act 170–173 ■ The Federal Trade Commission 184–185 ■ The WIPO Copyright Treaty 286–287



African commerce was given a boost in 2019 by the establishment of the African Continental Free Trade Area, enabling tariff-free trade between most of the continent's nations.

arms race, a stand-off with no obvious solution. At the same time, divisions between what were becoming known as the First and Third Worlds—the economically “developed” and “developing” countries—made the prospect of establishing any common means of commerce even less likely. The problem was not simply how such a variety of interests could be reconciled. It was that narrower national interests were always more likely to prevail than lofty aspirations. It is a contradiction that has never been resolved.

The multilateral trade talks that led to the creation of the WTO were known as the Uruguay Round because they began at Punta del Este in Uruguay. They took place within the framework of GATT from 1986 to 1993, with 123 nations taking part. Trade negotiations are

notoriously complex and slow-moving—China, for example, only signed up to the WTO in 2001, after 15 years of talks. That said, by 2020, the WTO had 164 member nations, who between them accounted for 98 percent of all global trade.

Basic mechanisms

The stated aim of the WTO is to ensure trade flows as smoothly, predictably, and freely as possible. It strives to eliminate protectionist, high import tariffs and so create »

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The WTO has one of the most impressive records in global economic governance.

Anna Lindh

Swedish politician (1957–2003)

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Seattle, 1999

The WTO is no stranger to internal disputes, often over matters of complex economic policy. From the late 1990s, external opposition emerged to any organization held to advance the exploitative, capitalist interests that were pushing a global neoliberal agenda—including the IMF, the World Bank, and the European Union, as well as the WTO. The WTO meeting in Seattle, Washington, in December 1999 saw this opposition reach a new pitch. In excess of 50,000 demonstrators descended on the city, protesting against environmental degradation, cheap imports, democratic unaccountability, unsafe work practices, or the existence of capitalism in general. Peaceful protests spiraled into violence, made worse by hamfisted attempts by the police to clear the streets. A new form of disruptive civic protest was born, whose offspring included the Occupy movement and Extinction Rebellion.



“The Battle of Seattle” occurred on November 30 and December 1, drawing attention to the effects of global trade.